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My Hard-Moment Protocol

Reference Card

Rooted in Real L

Your emotions are not the problem. They are information. When you are activated — flooded, triggered, reactive — your thinking brain goes offline. This protocol is what you do before you think. Three steps. Practiced in advance. Used in the moment.

1 Name It

Name what is happening inside you. Your pattern, your feeling, your response. Say it out loud if you can. Naming what you see creates a gap between the stimulus and your response. That gap is where freedom lives.

Examples: "This is the Judge." "This is anxiety." "This is the Pleaser trying to keep everyone safe." "I am in Flight right now."

2 Pray

Before you act, before you respond, before you do anything else — you turn. One sentence. You are not delivering a homily. You are simply turning toward God before you turn anywhere else. This is the T in R.O.O.T.E.D.

Examples: "Holy Spirit, I need You." "Lord, what is true right now?" "Father, I give this to You." "Jesus, I trust in You."

3 Elect

Not the perfect response. Not the ideal outcome. Just the one next right thing you can do that you will be at peace with tomorrow. One thing. Chosen. Not reacted.

Examples: "What is the one right thing to do right now?" "What would I choose if I weren't afraid?" "What does love actually ask of me here?"

“For God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control.” — 2 Timothy 1:7

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The Feelings Wheel

Start in the center · Move c

1. Find the core emotion in the center ring that feels closest to what you feel. 2. Move to the middle ring to name it more specifically. 3. Move to the outer ring for the most precise word. Circle what fits. Use more than one word if needed.

COLOR KEY

- Joy — excited, content, grateful, peaceful, hopeful
- Fear — anxious, insecure, ashamed, worried, nervous
- Sadness — lonely, grief, hurt, abandoned, hopeless
- Disgust — bored, resentful, bitter, envious, apathetic
- Anger — frustrated, irritated, overwhelmed, defeated
- Surprise — confused, amazed, lost, uncertain, awed

After finding your word…

→ Say it out loud
→ Where do you feel it in your body?
→ How long have you been carrying it?
→ What triggered it?

The word I am naming right now:

Where I feel it in my body:

What triggered it:

"You did not receive a spirit of slavery to fall back into fear." — Romans 8:15

Week 3 · The Root & the Remedy

Your emotions are not sinful. The Catechism teaches that passions are "neither good nor evil in themselves" (CCC 1767). They become morally significant by how we choose to respond to them. This week, before you respond — name what you feel. That is the beginning of moral freedom.

START HERE — NAME THE CORE FEELING

When something difficult happens, find the feeling in the center first. Then move outward to name it more precisely. Circle what fits.

Joy family	Excited · Content · Peaceful · Grateful · Hopeful
Fear family	Anxious · Insecure · Ashamed · Worried · Nervous
Sadness family	Lonely · Grieving · Hurt · Abandoned · Hopeless
Anger family	Frustrated · Irritated · Overwhelmed · Resentful · Bitter
Disgust family	Bored · Apathetic · Indifferent · Envious

AFTER YOU NAME IT

Where do I feel this in my body?	Your body holds what your mind won't always say. Chest tight. Throat closed. Shoulders up. Stomach hollow. Notice before you explain.
How long have I been carrying this?	Sometimes the feeling in the moment is carrying something from much further back. Give yourself the truth.
What triggered it?	Not to fix it. Not to justify it. Just to see it clearly. Reality before remedy.

THEN — THE HARD-MOMENT PROTOCOL

Once you have named the feeling, bring it to the protocol. Not to suppress it — to choose your response.

1 Name It	*Say what is happening. Out loud if possible.*
2 Pray	*One sentence. Turn before you act.*
3 Elect	*One next right thing. Chosen, not reacted.*

The feeling I am naming this week:

What happened when I named it instead of managed it:

E Week 5 · Breaking What Breaks You

Election is an Ignatian word for a deliberate, discerned choice. Not a reaction — a chosen action. By Week 5 you have named the pattern (O — Origin), felt the feeling (O — Overflow), and turned toward God (T — Turning). Now comes the moment of Election: what do you actually choose to do?

KNOW YOUR STRESS RESPONSE

When you are activated, your nervous system responds automatically. Which pattern is most recognisable in you? Circle it.

Fight	You attack, control, take charge, argue to win.	The Judge · The Controller
Flight	You escape, get busy, distract, avoid the feeling.	The Hyper-Achiever · The Avoider
Freeze	You shut down, go numb, can't move forward.	The Avoider · The Victim
Fawn	You appease, please, make yourself small.	The Pleaser · The Avoider

THE FULL HARD-MOMENT PROTOCOL

By now you have practiced the first two steps. This week the focus is on Step 3 — Election. What does it actually look like to choose freely?

1 Name It

Name the pattern or the feeling. Say it out loud. The naming creates the gap.

2 Pray

Turn before you act. One sentence. No performance required.

3 Elect

Small. Specific. Free. Not what keeps the peace. Not what manages the outcome. What is actually true and right.

A moment this week when I used the protocol:

What I chose — and what it felt like to choose freely:

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“For God gave us a spirit not of fear but of power and love and self-control.” — 2 Timothy 1:7

✂ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ Cut here ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ■ ✂

Write your own anchors in the lines inside each step. Keep this card somewhere you will actually see it — your mirror, your phone, the front of this journal. The goal is not to use it perfectly. The goal is to use it once — and notice what happens.

“You did not receive a spirit of slavery to fall back into fear.” — Romans 8:15